

Brabners

Complete firm and application research — programme structure, independent ownership, B-Corp status, values, sectors, clients, awards, and a full application-process breakdown.

Structure: 2 years Paralegal + 3 years Solicitor (optional year break between)

Academic requirement: BCC

Offices: Manchester, Leeds, Liverpool

2026 assessment dates: 26 May (Liverpool) · 27 May (Manchester)

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1. Programme Structure

Years 1-2	Paralegal
Years 3-5	Solicitor apprentice (can take an optional year's break between the paralegal and solicitor stages)
Final 2 years	Join trainees for shared seats/experience
Academic requirement	BCC at A Level (or equivalent)

2026 Legal Apprenticeship assessment dates

- 26 May 2026 — Liverpool
- 27 May 2026 — Manchester

2. Firm Overview

- An independent law firm — leadership sits with the people who work there, not an external owner, so the firm makes its own decisions based on what it actually needs
- Full-service, with a broad seat variety across Employment, Corporate, Litigation/Commercial Litigation, and Private Client
- Based across Manchester, Leeds and Liverpool — proud of its Northern base and heritage
- Part of the **Northern Ambition** network — a collaborative network for purpose-led businesses, focused on building a more sustainable and innovative future

3. Practice Areas & Sectors

EMPLOYMENT	CORPORATE	LITIGATION	COMMERCIAL LITIGATION	PRIVATE CLIENT	IP	COMMERCIAL	INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS
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Intellectual Property

Helps clients enforce their rights or defend an action brought against them efficiently and cost-effectively. Recognised by The Legal 500 for "strong experience." Helps safeguard IP investments through protection and registration of brands, inventions and designs, including audits reviewing a client's existing IP portfolio with a gap analysis for improving protection or exploitation. Also flags that domain name registrars/resellers don't check third-party rights or require proof of rights before registration.

Commercial

In a competitive economic climate, commercial contracts should help clients achieve business objectives and lock in the value of relationships, while providing clarity for the client, their customers and suppliers — covering preparation, tendering, challenging and responding to challenges, contract award, and managing compliance, disputes and performance across a contract's lifespan.

International Business

Covers all facets of international business administration — acquisitions, corporate structuring, commercial contracts and IP rights, through to employment law, regulatory advice and immigration.

Corporate

- Advises across the full business lifecycle: M&A, private equity investment, venture capital investment (including into high-growth businesses), group reorganisations, governance, business sales and exits, joint ventures, partnerships, LPs and LLPs
- Recognised as one of the UK's most active dealmakers by Experian — advised on 188 transactions in 2024, with a combined value of over £800m
- Ranked in the top tier of The Legal 500 2025 for corporate and commercial matters, with multiple team members recognised in the Hall of Fame, and as Leading Partners, Next Generation Partners, Leading Associates and Recommended Lawyers
- Can also draw on expertise from wider teams covering almost every legal specialism, plus dedicated sector teams for added insight

4. B-Corp Certification & Sustainability

- B-Corp certified — reflecting good organisational practice, sustainability, and strong people policies; profit is treated as one indicator of success, not the only one
- Guided by a stated mission to "make a difference"
- Named **Best Law Firm for Eco-Friendliness** at the Legal Cheek Awards 2025

Framed internally: success means sustainability and people matter, not just profit.

5. Values

- **Be Ambitious** — wants ambitious people who go above and beyond in everything they do, take ownership of their own careers, and drive their own development as far as it will go
- **Stand Together** — as a firm, but also alongside clients and communities; includes a community engagement group and charity/community work
- **Show You Care** — most firms are described as brutal and undifferentiated; this value is about caring for clients, communities and people specifically, deepening relationships and offering wider services as a result
- **Do What's Right** — described as the most important value, and the one that "gets you further" in the work than any other

The firm's values are displayed as imagery in every office.

6. Clients

Notable clients include Liverpool FC, Panasonic, Primark, and Wetherspoons — plus involvement in the high-profile Colleen Rooney case. This client base is seen as a route to genuinely important, valuable work as an apprentice.

7. Awards & Recognition

- Highly commended in the "Independent Law Firm of the Year" category — The Lawyer Awards 2024
- Recognised as the Best Law Firm to Work For, and the sixth Best Large Company to Work For in the UK, by Best Companies
- Best Law Firm for Eco-Friendliness — Legal Cheek Awards 2025

8. Application Process — Full Breakdown

Before applying

- Identify your desired career outcome and check it genuinely matches your aspirations
- Go beyond the website — attend firm events, speak to people who actually work there
- Use Legal 500, Legal Cheek, Future Lawyers, and anonymous trainee surveys as research for "why do you want to work here" — work-life balance and personal reasons are legitimate, important motivations to include
- Check the firm's policy on AI use for touch-ups/rewording of application answers before submitting

Application questions

- Be clear on why Brabners specifically — explain and apply 2-3 clear points
- Outline your top few skills
- Show that you understand yourself — avoid generic claims like "I'm a team player"; demonstrate skills through real life experience instead
- Draw from work experience, legal expeditions/insight events, hobbies, societies and volunteering — give these roughly equal weight and variety, rather than over-relying on one type

Commercial awareness

Take time to prepare a genuine commercial interest and be able to explain why you have it. This is about the ability to understand what makes a business successful, think logically when given information, and think creatively — not about how well you already understand law or business as subjects.

Situational Judgement Test & video interview

- All outcome options in the SJT are "right" in some sense — they each underpin different skills, so there isn't a single "correct" answer being tested

Group task / debate

Described as casual — a chance to learn debate skills and how to succeed commercially as a group. Being structured matters; the firm is also using the exercise to help educate candidates on how Brabners itself thinks.

3-minute presentation

On a topic of your choice — designed to showcase who you are as a person. Feedback suggests the most distinctive, unique topics have been the most successful.

Written task

You'll be given a document and asked to identify errors, what's missing, and what shouldn't be included. Keep double-checking your work throughout — you are not marked down for an incorrect identification, so it's worth flagging anything you're unsure about rather than omitting it.

Interview style

- Strength-based interview, not competency-based — expect questions like "what do you think makes a day successful?" rather than "tell

me about a time you showed resilience"

- There isn't much administrative work involved in the role day-to-day
- Be ready to answer what you would most enjoy about being a trainee

9. Application Tips

- Use the **Point, Explain, Apply** structure for contextual/motivation-style questions
- Use **STAR** (Situation, Task, Action, Result) for competency-style questions where relevant

10. Personal Fit Notes

Space to develop personal talking points against Brabners' specific values and application style.

- The firm's independent, worker-led ownership model and B-Corp status offer a genuine point of differentiation worth referencing directly, rather than only discussing sectors or deals
- Given the strength-based interview style, prepare examples framed around what makes work genuinely enjoyable and successful day-to-day, not just examples of overcoming difficulty
- The emphasis on non-legal experience (hobbies, societies, volunteering) carrying equal weight to legal work experience is worth using deliberately — avoid front-loading only legal insight days

Sources: [brabners.com](#) sector and careers pages; Legal Cheek Awards 2025; The Lawyer Awards 2024; firm-hosted research webinar notes. Compiled as private research — verify current salary, deadline and programme details against the live listing before applying.